

hack work—producing piano transcriptions, creating a piano course for children, and helping other composers. His own compositions were often rushed or abandoned for lack of time. *Carmen* (1875) should have changed all that. Based on Prosper Mérimée's powerful novella (see box), it had hot-blooded characters, Spanish and Romany rhythms, and the mercurial Célestine Galli-Marié singing the lead. Yet Bizet's opera shocked Parisian audiences, who were appalled by the rawness of the passions, the on-stage murder of Carmen by her jealous ex-lover Don José, and scenes in which women smoked. Because it had spoken dialogue rather than recitative, it was staged at the Opéra-Comique, which normally hosted more gentle productions. Nonetheless, Bizet's masterpiece has become one of the world's most popular operas. With its brutal plot and passionate characters, it went on to influence the verismo (realism) movement.